the real in it is the *Ātman* alone. The most pervading thought is that the *Ātman* is the only reality, though in places we also find the pantheistic thought which identifies the universe with the *Brāhmaṇ* and the theistic thought which looks upon the *Brāhmaṇ* as the Lord of the Universe.

The *Ātman* is characterized as transcendental and beyond the reach of the senses and the intellect. It is a pure, subject-objectless consciousness. Sometimes it is identified with *Brāhmaṇ*, as in the sayings, *That thou art (tat tvam asi)* and *I am Brāhmaṇ (aham brāhma asmi).* But the meaning is that the *Ātman* alone underlies man and nature and not that there are two realities which are one. Demonstrating that it is *not this, not this (neti, neti),* the indescribability of the *Brāhmaṇ* is also stressed.

Next, after the doctrine of the *Ātman* and its realization, is the doctrine of transmigration. The significance of this doctrine is that it points to desire and not to *Karma* as the cause of rebirth. *Karma* only forms the connecting link between desire and rebirth, for "whatever a man desires he wills, and whatever he wills he acts." Desire is annihilated by Self-knowledge. *Mokṣa* (emancipation) is the state of infiniteness which a man attains when he realizes his own Self. Transmigration naturally ceases for such a knowing man. He transcends limits and is happy, for the infinite is bliss, just as the finite is pain. Emancipation is not the attainment of something that is not: it is only the true knowledge of the Self that ever is.

THE EPICS AND THE BHAGAVAD-GĪTĀ

A few centuries of thought, separating the Vedic period from the later systems, are embodied in the epic of the *Mahābhārata* containing the *Bhagavad-Gītā* of the Lord Krishna and some minor *Upaniṣads.* The continuation of Vedic monotheism, the emergence of two new creeds *(Śaivism* and *Vaiśnavism* glorifying the Vedic deities of *Śiva* and *Vishnu* respectively), the concept of *Dharma* as predominantly ritualistic, and various other notions of *Bhakti* (devotion) and *Prasāda* (divine grace) are the chief philosophical features of this period. During this period the concepts of *Karma* and *Mokṣa* were refined. The *Gītā,* second only to the *Upaniṣads* in philosophical importance, advocates *Niṣkāma-karma,* or performance of duty without thought of consequences. According to the *Gītā,* one's own duty *(Sva-dharma)* is relative to one's social status. Every duty is as good as every other; only it is to be done in a spirit of non-attachment *(Karma-yoga).* Duty in the *Gītā,* how-